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WALTER SMITH

THE VIṢṆU IMAGE IN THE SHORE TEMPLE AT MĀMALLAPURAM*

The Shore temple at Māmallapuram, on the southeastern coast of India, about sixty kilometers south of Madras, is one of India's most celebrated monuments. Its name refers to the temple's picturesque location on Māmallapuram's beach, where it overlooks the Bay of Bengal. The temple's present shape, as a complex of three shrines, two of them with tall superstructures, dates to the first quarter of the eighth century. About a century earlier, however, the temple consisted only of the rectangular shrine now situated between the two taller ones (figs. 1 and 2).¹ This rectangular shrine houses a unique image of the god Viṣṇu (figs. 3 and 4). The figure reclines on a plain slab or platform. Originally four-armed, the upper right limb is now broken. The image also suffers from extensive erosion. Except for the tall conical crown typical of Viṣṇu images, the figure is unencumbered by additional iconographical elements. In this regard, it is much simpler than other reclining Viṣṇu images from the same general period, whether in southern or northern India.² More usually, as seen in a rendering from Deogarh, in northern India (fig. 5), images of reclining, or sleeping Viṣṇu usually show him lying on the coils of the cosmic serpent Ananta, and in this case he is called Anantaśāyin (sleeping on Ananta). Serpents being symbolic of water, Ananta can be identified with the primordial ocean upon which Viṣṇu sleeps during his cosmic "night" – which lasts for eons and is the period in cosmic time when the phenomenal world is in a state of dissolution.³ The Deogarh relief is usually interpreted as depicting the very end of Viṣṇu's sleep, when he awakens to once more give form to the universe. The god Brahmā, seated on the lotus which emerges from Viṣṇu's navel, is the divinity commonly associated with creation. Here, however, he is seen as the creative agent of Viṣṇu. The remaining figures in the Deogarh relief also play a role – too elaborate to go into here – in the myth of Viṣṇu's creation of the Universe.⁴

The main thesis to be presented here is that despite its iconographic simplicity, the sleeping Viṣṇu at Māmallapuram was created as a vivid evocation of Viṣṇu on the cosmic ocean, and specifically, that elements of nature itself were used consciously as artistic materials. This interpretation is based first of all on the fact that the Viṣṇu image was carved *in situ* out of living rock. Secondly, the proximity of the sea also seems to have been involved in the original conception of the image. Indeed,

* My thanks to Michael Rabe for his critique of an earlier version of this essay.

¹ The original appearance of the Viṣṇu shrine is unknown, as it seems to have been largely reconstructed in the eighth century. For a discussion of the building phases of the Shore temple see Jacques Dumarçay and Françoise L'Hernault, *Temples Pallava Construits* (Paris, 1975), 18–22 and pl. XIX.

² For the iconography of the reclining form of Viṣṇu (Sthalaśāyin, Anantaśāyin, Śeṣaśāyin, Nārāyaṇa) see Nanditha Krishna, *Art and Iconography of Vishnu-Narayana* (Bombay, 1980); R. Champakalakshmi, *Vaiṣṇava Iconography in the Tamil Country* (Delhi, 1981), 66–79; Ratan Parimoo, *Sculptures of Śeṣaśāyī Viṣṇu* (Baroda, 1983), 101–11; and G. Sharma, "The Significance of Viṣṇu Reclining on the Serpent," *Religion* 16, no. 2 (April 1986), 104–14.

³ Heinrich Zimmer, *Myths and Symbols in Indian Art and Civilization*, ed. Joseph Campbell (Princeton, 1946), 35–38.

⁴ For detailed accounts of the Anantaśāyin myth see Sharma, "Significance of Viṣṇu", and Parimoo, *Śeṣaśāyī*, 13–17. Zimmer describes the Deogarh relief in *Myths and Symbols*, 60–61. His misidentification of the figures standing at the base as the five Pāṇḍava brothers and their wife Draupadī is corrected by Wayne E. Begley, *Viṣṇu's Flaming Wheel: The Iconography of the Sudarśana Cakra* (New York, 1973), 48–49, where they are identified as the personifications of Viṣṇu's weapons battling two demons (the figures on the left).

the ocean may have been considered as a kind of extension of the image, evoking the cosmic sea upon which Viṣṇu sleeps. Such an integrated synthesis of nature and art exists not only in regard to the Viṣṇu image and its shrine, but was also a major factor in the aesthetic of the entire site of Māmallapuram.

That Māmallapuram is an extraordinary site is evident from views of its landscape (figs. 6 and 7). The site is dominated by huge granite boulders and outcroppings, this being the material out of which most of the temples, both rock-cut and structural, are formed. The site seems almost alive, the rock forms suggestive of living shapes. The light is bright and intense, reflecting off the stone and the sandy ground. The seaside atmosphere is crystalline. This vivid aliveness must have impressed the original builders of the monuments, who chose to develop the site as an embodiment of the living presence of several divinities. Various Indian writings tell us that the presence of the gods is to be felt in nature – in rocks, trees, rivers, mountains and caves. One text dating to the fifth century, the *Bṛhat Saṃhitā* tells us that “it is such places that the gods love, and always dwell in”.⁵ Other writings, the Indian epics and collections of myths and legends called *Purāṇas*, speak vividly of the beauty of nature and the presence of divinity within it, particularly when they describe sacred sites, or the hermitages of holy men who practice yoga and asceticism.⁶ At Māmallapuram, it is through a subtle interplay between artistic manipulation and qualities inherent in the landscape itself that the builders have attempted to intensify the viewer’s awareness of the gods’ presence.

The creators of the rock-cut and structural temples of Māmallapuram were the kings of the Pallava dynasty, who ruled the region surrounding Māmallapuram from the third or fourth century to the end of the ninth. The specific roles played by individual kings in the development of the site, however, are problematic. The rock-cut temples are frequently attributed to King Narasimhavarman I Māmalla (r. ca. 630–68), for whom the site is named. A recent study by Marilyn Hirsh suggests, however, that it was Narasimhavarman’s father, the more artistically inclined Mahendravarman (r. ca. 571–630), the author of two Sanskrit plays and treatises on painting and music, who was responsible for the majority of work at the site.⁷ The absence of dedicatory inscriptions naming either king as patron leaves questions of attribution open.⁸

As just stated, the Viṣṇu image at Māmallapuram was carved out of a boulder on the site itself, the shrine later being built around it. It is very likely that the original shape of the rock itself was suggestive of the image to be carved from it. Several other works at Māmallapuram have this quality, the most well known being the celebrated relief possibly depicting the Descent of the River Ganges (fig. 8). Here a natural cleft at the top of the rock may have inspired an image of the river’s descent from heaven as a waterfall surrounded by celestial beings on either side.⁹ Comparison with the

⁵ *Bṛhat Saṃhitā*, 55.8. Cited by Stella Kramrisch, *The Hindu Temple*, vol. 1 (Calcutta, 1946), 2.

⁶ See J.A.B. van Buitenen, *The Mahābhārata. Vol. 1: The Book of the Beginning* (Chicago, 1973), 158–59. See also *Liṅga Purāṇa*, trans. J.L. Shastri (Delhi, 1973), 51.1 ff. (197–98); and *Vāyu Purāṇa*, trans. G.V. Tagare, vol. 1 (Delhi, 1987), 1.47 ff. (304–10).

⁷ Marilyn Hirsh, “Mahendravarman I Pallava: Artist and Patron of Māmallapuram”, *Artibus Asiae* 48, nos. 1/2 (1987), 109–30. Michael Rabe has recently presented compelling evidence that Narasimhavarman I was the patron of the great “Descent of the Ganges” relief. Michael Rabe, “The Māmallapuram Prasasti: A Eulogy in Figures,” paper presented at the American Committee for South Asian Art, Symposium VI, New York City, April 22, 1994.

⁸ For recent general discussions of the Pallavas and Māmallapuram see C. Sivaramamurti, *Māmallapuram* (4th ed., New Delhi, 1978); Michael D. Rabe, “The Monolithic Temples of the Pallava Dynasty: A Chronology”, 3 vols. (Ph. D. dissertation, University of Minnesota, 1987). Hirsh and Rabe also present extensive bibliographies.

⁹ Also at Māmallapuram is a smaller, unfinished (even more so than the great relief) version of the “Descent of the Ganges”, which appears to have been carved from two *separate* boulders. For an illustration see Albert H. Longhurst, *Pallava Architecture*, part 2: Intermediate or Māmalla Period (Delhi, 1930, reprint Delhi, 1980), pl. XXXIII.

unaltered landscape, as seen particularly in Figure 6, gives us some idea of the overall suggestivity of the site, and of what the sculpted rock might originally have looked like. Another example is the so-called Lion-Cave, a small rock-cut shrine possibly dedicated originally to the goddess Durgā, located at Śāḷuvankuppan, about two miles north of the Shore temple (fig. 9). Here the rounded curves of the rock take the shape of a cluster of lion heads, and part of the side of the rock also takes on a lion-form.¹⁰ Less monumental are the rock-cut sculptures only a short distance south of the temple itself. The Durgā-rock (fig. 10) is a miniature rock-cut shrine to that goddess, the rounded shape of the stone suggesting the form of Durgā's lion-vehicle. In all of these works the artist has been interested in giving solid shape to something that was previously only suggestively, perhaps very subtly, present. And it may also be true that the reason particular images were carved into particular rocks, is that specific divinities were felt to be especially present within them. This seems to have been particularly true of the low-lying horizontal rock formation out of which the Shore temple's Viṣṇu was carved.

Another factor compelling the artist/patron to carve this rock into the shape of Sleeping Viṣṇu may have been the proximity of the sea itself. It seems highly likely that the image and its shrine were meant periodically to be washed, and at times, such as the monsoon season, even inundated by the waves of the ocean, dramatically recreating Viṣṇu's primordial environment. At the present time, however, direct contact between temple and sea is prevented by an extension of rock and a protective wall, erected early in the twentieth century and subsequently refurbished, which protect the temple from the damaging effects of the ocean's waves (fig. 11).¹¹ A nineteenth-century drawing gives us some idea of how the temple looked before these protective measures were taken (fig. 12). It has frequently been suggested that the temple was originally built much further from the shore, and that land erosion has brought the temple closer to the sea relatively recently.¹² But physical evidence on the temple itself counters this view. The lower walls of the temple are extremely eroded, showing direct contact with water – not just sea air – over a long period of time (fig. 13). In contrast, the superstructure is much less eroded – while somewhat worn by the salt air, it is clear and sharp in comparison to the lower walls (fig. 14). The point I am making here is that the temple and its images were purposely built close to the shore, and that their proximity to the sea had artistic, symbolic, and even ritual reasons behind it.

Aside from its physical appearance, there is substantial literary evidence which suggests that the Shore temple was in direct contact with the sea from the time it was built, and that this contact was part of its aesthetic and meaning. The poet and prose writer Daṇḍin was associated with the court of

¹⁰ A comparison with the rock-cut Hell-mouth entrance to the Parco dei Mostri, Bomarzo, Italy, a sixteenth-century "earthwork" is here irresistible. For illustrations and discussion see Esther Gordon Dotson, "Shapes of Earth and Time in European Gardens", *Art Journal* 42, no. 3 (Fall 1982), 210–16. Here too something in the natural appearance of the stone may have suggested the imagery to be drawn out by the artist.

¹¹ Sivaramamurti, *Mamallapuram*, 32; and Longhurst, *Pallava Architecture*, part 3: The Later or Rajasima Period, 2.

¹² Longhurst, *Pallava Architecture*, part 3, 2. Several other early British and American writers cite legends of "undersea temples" claimed by the advancing tides, no traces of which have ever been found. Two early sources, among others, are Eliza R. Scidmore, *Winter India* (London, 1903); and William H. Workman and Fanny B. Workman, *Through Town and Jungle* (London, 1904). Cited in N. S. Ramaswami, *Mamallapuram: An Annotated Bibliography* (Madras, 1980), 75–79. Geological evidence indicates that much of southern India's coastline consists of "raised beaches", land that was undersea about 30,000 years ago. See A. K. Dey, "The Shore Lines of India", *Quaternaria* 3 (1956), 303–29; S. Krishnaswamy, "The Coasts of India", *Indian Geographical Journal* 29, no. 1 (1960), 18–22; A. Sarma, "The Paleogeography of Coastal Tamilnadu, South India: Chronology of Raised Beaches", *Proceedings of the American Philosophical Society* 122, no. 6 (December 1978), 411–26.

the Pallava kings during the late seventh and early eighth centuries.¹³ In one of his works, the *Avantisundarikathā*, he describes in the prologue an episode from his own life, from which I here quote and paraphrase. Daṇḍin and several friends have gone to see “the image of Viṣṇu reclining on his serpent bed on the shore of Māhamallapuram”. One of these friends is an artisan named Lalitālaya, who had repaired an arm on the image that had been broken. Lalitālaya asks his friends to see if his repairs are “worthy of the image which is a work of art of the great ancient architects”. The next day they set out. On the shore they sight “a lofty temple, all in white, and the tumultuous billows dashing against its base. Proceeding a little distance they beheld the image, the sea brushing its feet with gentle ripples. They came closer to the image, but could not discover any traces of mending in the arms”. (The repairs, then, were a success.) The image is further described by Daṇḍin as looking “fresh again and again when the water in the sea rose up in the form of blue mighty waves and washed the body”. The narrative goes on to describe “a big red lotus floating over the sea and moving slowly towards the image. It touched the feet of the image and suddenly turned in a Vidyādhara [celestial being]”. The vidyādhara “went round, making obeisance to the deity and vanished in the sky”. Daṇḍin said that a celestial being must have offended a sage “in an incident connected with flowers, and the sage cursed him to change into a lotus flower, and the flower having floated over the sea for long ages received its original form at the touch of the image”.¹⁴

This passage is remarkable in how it evokes the “aliveness” of the Viṣṇu image. The wandering vidyādhara, searching for the god who sleeps upon the waters, finds him in the image on the shore. Thus the traditional Hindu concept of the image as *mūrti* (form, embodiment) is rendered with great vividness by Daṇḍin in his narrative.

Even though these excerpts are part of a romance, there is a quality of direct reporting and first-hand description here, even when combined with the fantastic appearance of the lotus. Interesting too, and hardly incidental, is that one of the image’s arms is broken today. Could it be that this is the broken arm repaired, possibly with stucco, by Lalitālaya, Daṇḍin’s artisan friend?

A problematic aspect of Daṇḍin’s description of the Viṣṇu image is that he describes it as “reclining on a serpent bed”, even though the image actually rests on a plain platform. There are, however, a few ways in which the problem may be reconciled. Possibly, the serpentine elements were originally rendered in paint or stucco, such elements of course having long since worn off. Michael Lockwood has even suggested that elements of the serpent’s anatomy, well worn with time, can still be discerned here.¹⁵ Or perhaps, in mentioning the serpent bed, the poet was simply recalling the standard iconographical form of the god. The third possibility is that a different image than the one in the Shore temple was seen and described by Daṇḍin, though this seems unlikely. The only other early image of sleeping Viṣṇu at Māmallapuram – this time actually on the serpent Ananta – is in the Mahiṣāsura-mardinī cave-temple, about half a mile inland from the shore (fig. 15).¹⁶ Here many of the narrative elements, as seen at Deogarh, are also depicted. My final suggestion regarding Daṇḍin is

¹³ For Daṇḍin’s date see V. V. Mirashi, “Historical Data in Daṇḍin’s *Daśakumāracarita*”, *Annals of the Bhandarkar Oriental Research Institute* 26 (1943), reprinted in *Studies in Indology* I, Nagpur (1960), 31; V. A. Ramaswami Sastri, “Avantisundari: A Study”, *Journal of the Tanjore Saraswati Mahal Library* 10 (1955–56), 23; and D. K. Gupta, *Society and Culture in the Time of Daṇḍin* (Delhi, 1972), 13–19. On p. 14 Gupta cogently argues against earlier dates that have been proposed for Daṇḍin.

¹⁴ *Avantisundarikathā*, 2nd ed., K. S. Mahadeva Sastri, ed. (Trivandrum, 1954). The relevant passages are summarized in Ramaswami, *Mamallapuram*, 9–10; and Champakalaksmi, *Vaiṣṇava Iconography*, 74.

¹⁵ Michael Lockwood, *Mamallapuram and the Pallavas* (Madras, 1982), 3–4.

¹⁶ The Talaśayana-perumāḷ temple and its reclining Viṣṇu image date to the Vijayanagara period (15th–16th century). Sivaramurti, *Mahabalipuram*, 29.

that he has combined his impressions of both works in his description of the image on the shore. At any rate, what Daṇḍin does describe is an image that is integral with its surroundings, which complete it artistically.

A copper-plate inscription from the sixth regnal year of the Pallava king Nṛpatuṅga (*ca.* 875) states that king Narasimhavarman I built a “sleeping chamber” for Lord Viṣṇu, “with stones, on the ocean”.¹⁷ Aside from giving us a clue as to the identity of the patron of the earliest part of the Shore temple, if not the image within it (remember that Daṇḍin calls the image a work of the “great ancient architects”), we have here a solid reference to the temple’s being in close proximity to the sea during the ninth century. Additional references from inscriptions on the Shore temple itself lend further weight to the suggestion that the sea was considered as part of the image. Two separate inscriptions of the eleventh century name the aspect of Viṣṇu enshrined in the temple as Jalaśayana, “resting on water”.¹⁸ This is a name also associated with Viṣṇu images shown resting on the coils of the cosmic serpent, which, as mentioned earlier, can be identified with the primordial sea. Calling the Shore temple image “Jalaśayana” seems to indicate that it is the water from the adjacent ocean itself that Viṣṇu rests upon. Thus it seems that in pre-modern times the image was constantly washed by the ocean’s waves, and at particular times of year the waves could totally engulf the figure, lending toward an intense heightening of the imagery of Viṣṇu asleep on the cosmic ocean.

That the incorporation of water with images of sleeping Viṣṇu was not unique to the Shore temple is seen in an image from a ritual bathing tank near the Viṣṇu temple at Buddha Nilakaṇṭha in Nepal (fig. 16), an example of environmental sculpture strongly akin to the work from Māmallapuram, with which, interestingly, it is roughly contemporary. The further use of water as an artistic element can be seen at Māmallapuram itself. I have already mentioned that in the Descent of the Ganges relief, the natural cleft in the rock was worked into an image of a waterfall, with serpentine water deities serving as further symbolic indicators of the river’s presence. But actual water played a role in the original artistic conception as well, in that a cistern was once positioned on top of the boulder. As the water flowed through the cleft it turned the relief into a kind of fountain and a *tableau vivant*, dramatically re-enacting the river’s descent.¹⁹ For the Viṣṇu image the natural proximity of water has a similarly evocative effect.

The proximity of the sea, then, seems to have been part of the original aesthetic of the Shore temple, suggestive of the cosmic ocean upon which Viṣṇu sleeps. But water may have had a ritual function as well. A standard ritual in Hindu worship involves bathing or lustrating the sacred image. At the Shore temple, nature itself pays such homage. In the writings of Daṇḍin cited earlier, the poet describes the waves as lapping at the feet and washing the body of Viṣṇu. Another south Indian poet, Mahādeviyakka, who lived in the Karṇāṭaka region of southern India during the twelfth century, is even more explicit in describing nature’s veneration of divinity. She sings to the god Śiva:

¹⁷ N. Ramesan, “Studies in Medieval Deccan History, Based on Two New Unpublished Copper Plate Inscriptions of the State Museum, Hyderabad”, *Andhra Pradesh Government Archaeological Series* 29, Hyderabad (1972), 8; summarized in Ramaswamy, *Mamallapuram*, II; and translated in Rabe, “Monolithic Temples”, 255.

¹⁸ Eugen Hultzsch, *South Indian Inscriptions*, vol. I (Madras, 1890), 63–66, inscription no. 40; and 66–68, inscription no. 41.

¹⁹ For a reconstruction drawing see Longhurst, *Pallava Architecture*, part 2, pl. XXXII.

Sunlight made visible
the whole length of a sky,
movement of wind,
leaf, flower, all six colours
on tree, bush and creeper:

all this
is the day's worship.

The light of moon, star and fire,
lightnings and all things
that go by the name of light
are the night's worship.

Night and day
in your worship
I forget myself

O lord white as jasmine.²⁰

The poet thus describes all of nature to be in perpetual worship before the god, making her own rituals superfluous.²¹

At Māmallapuram the ocean performs this function as well. This is perhaps most clearly seen in an unfinished rock-cut shrine immediately adjacent to the Shore temple (fig. 17). From some views it appears simply as a boulder on the sea shore, from others it is revealed as a rock-cut shrine (as much eroded as unfinished). It houses an image of the goddess Durgā, and faces the sea. And with the regularity of the tides, the goddess receives her ritual lustrations from the ocean itself, making the veneration of mortals needless.

Human intervention, in the interest of historic preservation, has denied the ocean its daily worship of Lord Viṣṇu at the Shore temple. Necessary as this intervention is, it obscures the integrative and interactive nature of the Shore temple's aesthetic. My hope is that the comments and suggestions made here begin to reclarify this integrative quality, not only in regard to the Shore temple, but to the entire network of artistic form that is Māmallapuram.

²⁰ Translated in A. K. Ramanujan, *Speaking of Śiva* (London, 1973), 130.

²¹ Cf. Ramanujan, *Śiva*, 195. It might well be asked that if the siting of the Viṣṇu image facing the sea was so conscious, why was such an obscuring addition, the eighth-century Śiva shrine, subsequently built in front of it. I believe that a combination of "sectarian rivalry" and political motivation was responsible. This is the subject of a study I am currently preparing.



Fig. 1. *Māmallapuram*, Shore Temple. 7th–8th centuries, general view.

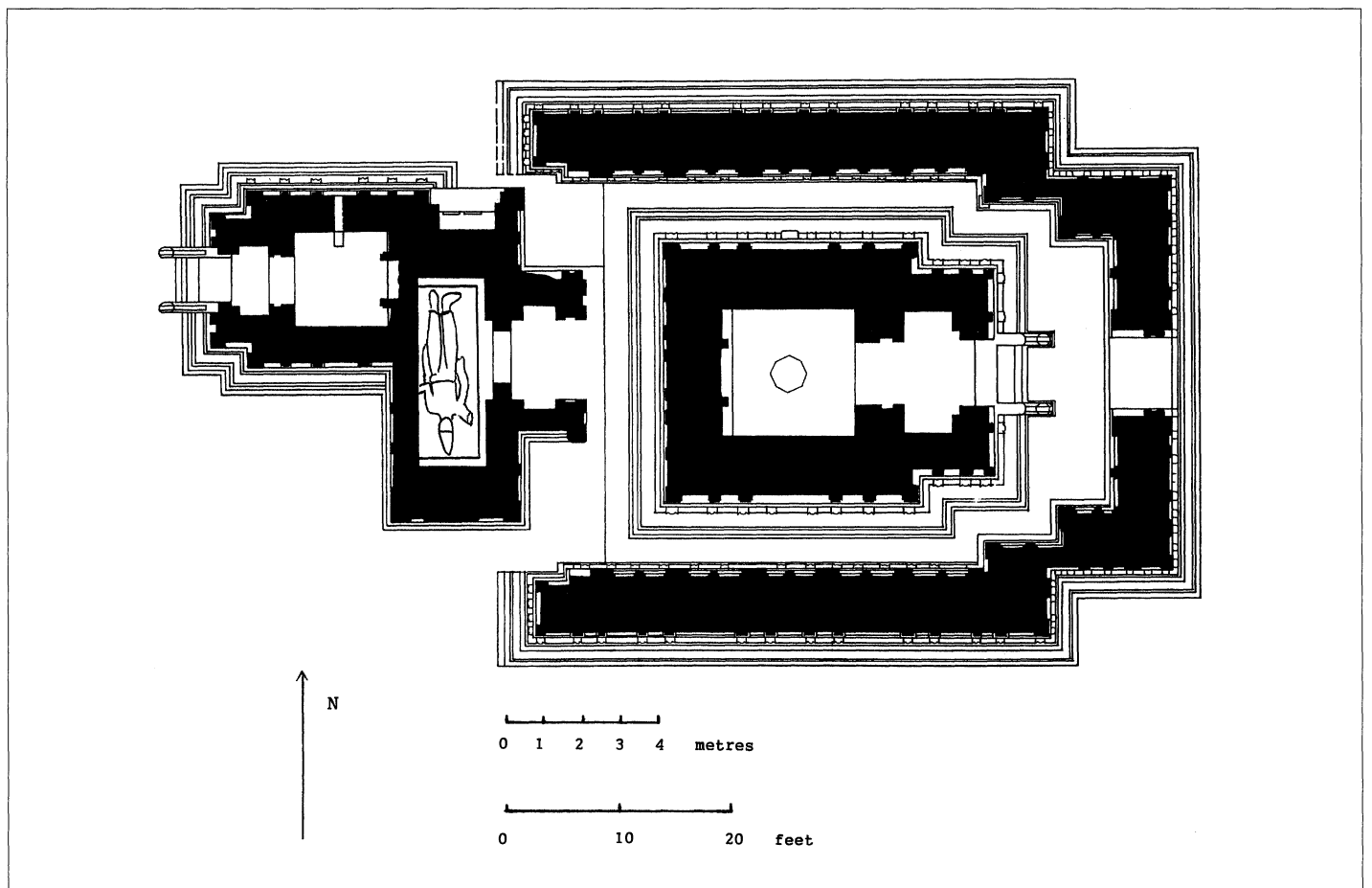


Fig. 2. *Shore temple*, ground plan. (After Michael W. Meister, ed., *Encyclopaedia of Indian Temple Architecture: South India, Lower Drāviḍadēśa* [Delhi, 1983]).

Photographs are by the author unless otherwise noted.



Fig. 3. *Viṣṇu, Shore temple, left side of image.*
(Photograph: Michael Rabe).



Fig. 4. *Viṣṇu, Shore temple, right side of image.*
(Photograph: Michael Rabe).



Fig. 5. *Deogarh, Daśāvatāra Temple, Viṣṇu Anantaśāyīn. 6th century.*



Fig. 6. *Māmallapuram, general view.*

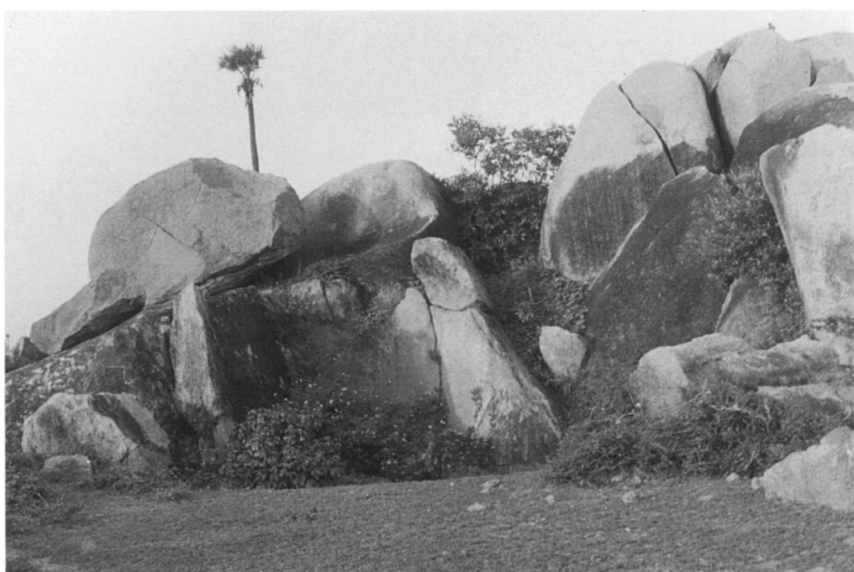


Fig. 7. *Māmallapuram, general view.*

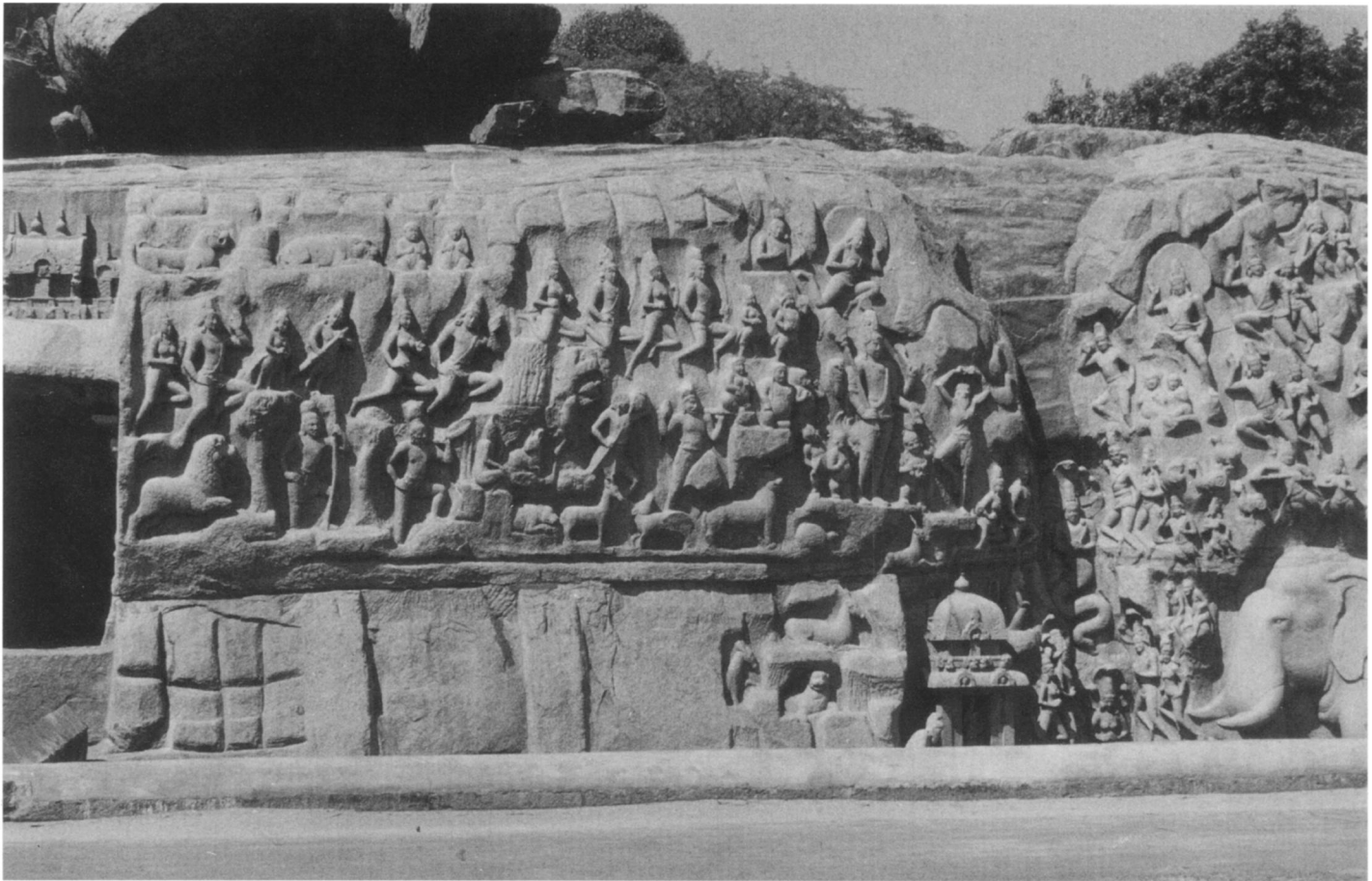


Fig. 8. *Māmallapuram, Descent of the Ganges*. Ca. 7th century.



Fig. 9. *Sāluvankuppan, near Māmallapuram, Lion-Cave*. Ca. late 7th–early 8th century.



Fig. 10. *Māmallapuram, Durgā-Rock*. Ca. 7th–8th century.



Fig. 11. *Shore temple, view showing land extension.*

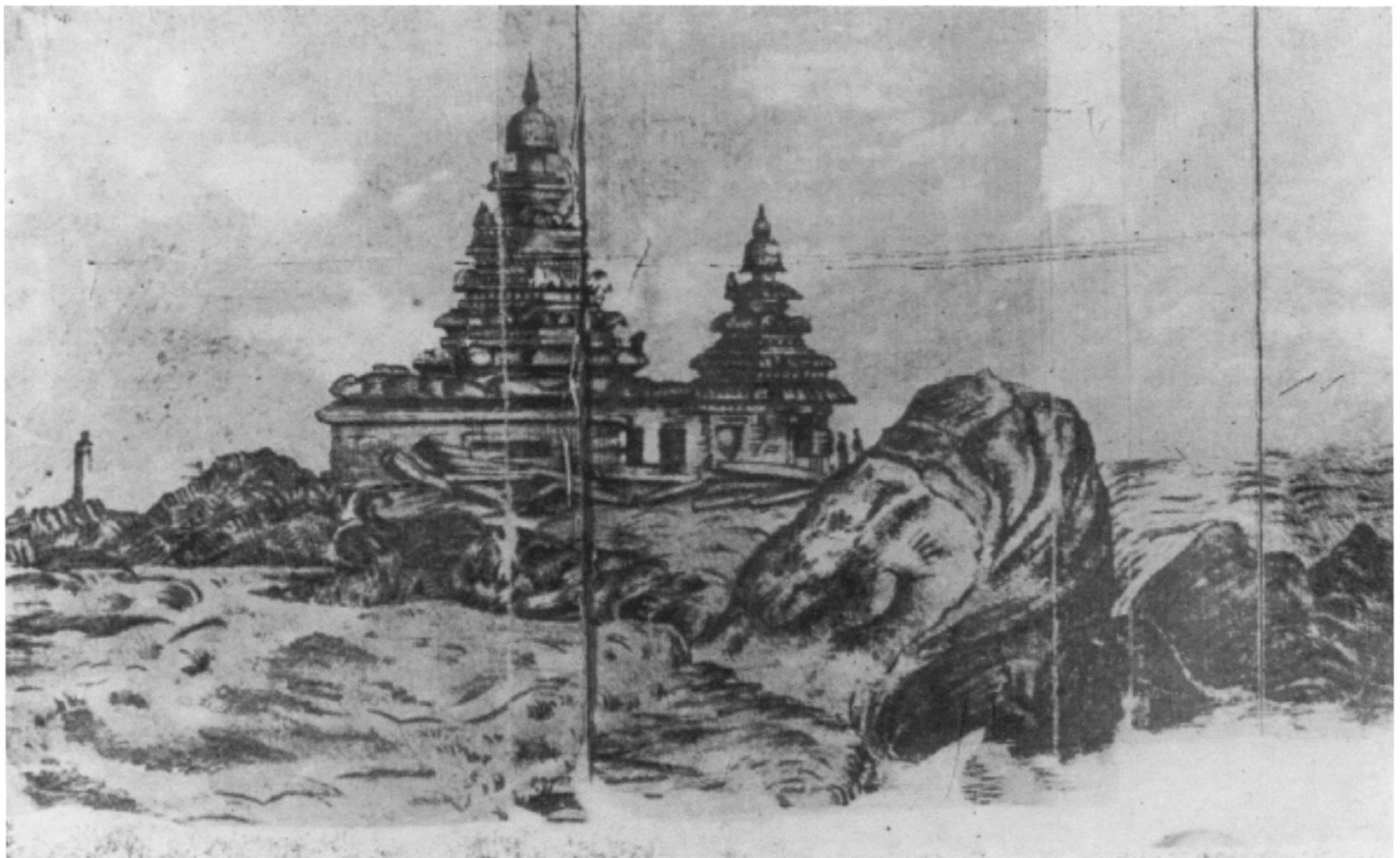


Fig. 12. *Shore temple.* 19th-century drawing. (From Mark W. Carr, ed., *Descriptive and Historical Papers Relating to the Seven Pagodas on the Coromandel Coast* [Madras, 1869], reprinted in N. S. Ramaswami, *Māmallapuram: An Annotated Bibliography* [Madras, 1980]).



Fig. 14. *Shore temple, superstructure.*



Fig. 13. *Shore temple, lower walls.*

Fig. 15. *Māmallapuram, Mahiṣāmardini Cave, Viṣṇu Anantaśāyin*. Ca. 7th century.

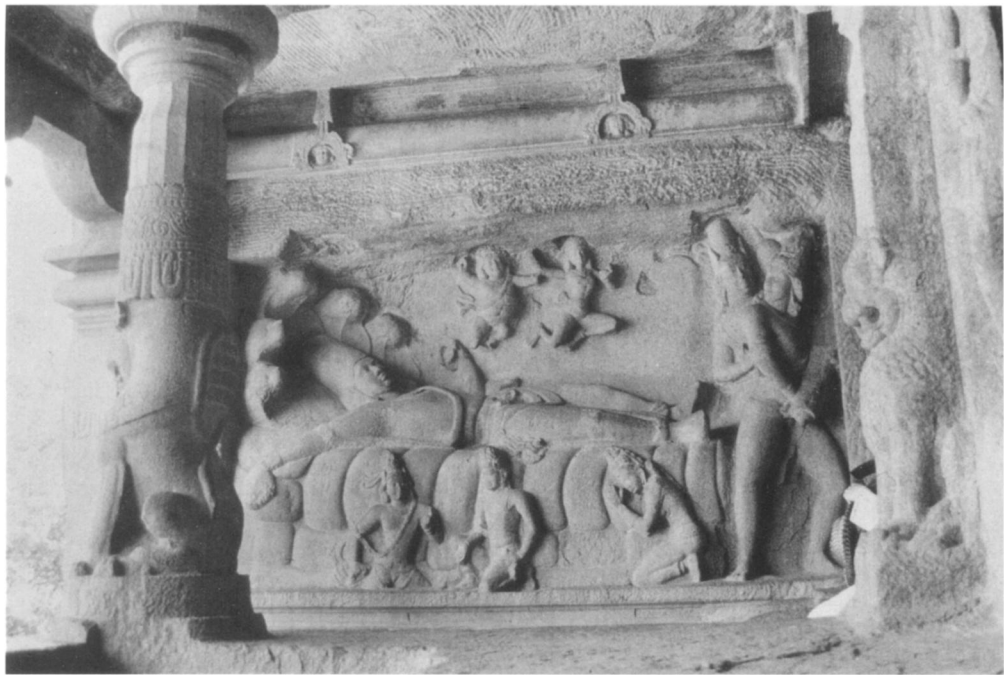


Fig. 16. *Buddha Nīlakaṇṭha, Nepal, Viṣṇu Anantaśāyin*. 7th century.
(Photograph: Asian Art Archives, University of Michigan).

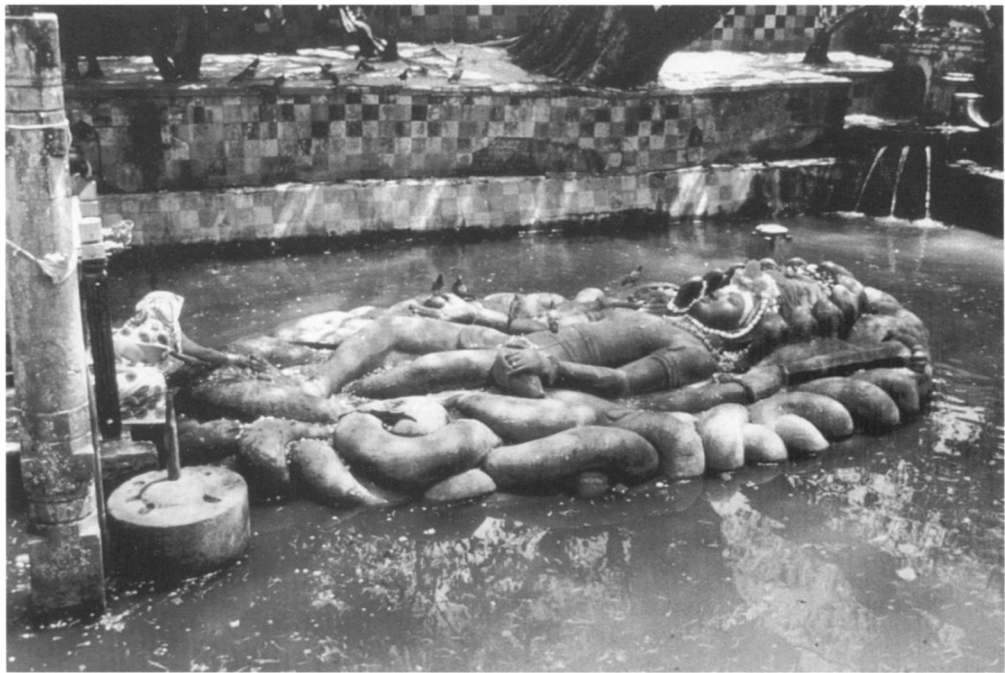


Fig. 17. *Māmallapuram, Rock-cut Durgā shrine north of the Shore temple*. Ca. 7th–8th century.

